



Food & Dining

Chinese cuisine, restaurant recommendations, cooking tips

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Article 1

The 8 Great Cuisines of China: A Complete Guide

Chinese cuisine is not monolithic -- it encompasses 8 major regional traditions, each with distinct flavors, techniques, and ingredients.

1. Cantonese (粤菜) -- Guangdong

Known for: Fresh ingredients, dim sum, subtle flavors. Signature dishes: Char siu (BBQ pork), har gow (shrimp dumplings), siu mai, roast goose. Best in: Guangzhou, Hong Kong.

2. Sichuan (川菜) -- Sichuan

Known for: Mala (numbing-spicy) flavor from Sichuan peppercorns. Signature dishes: Mapo tofu, kung pao chicken, hot pot, dan dan noodles. Best in: Chengdu.

3. Shandong (鲁菜) -- Shandong

Known for: Seafood, braised dishes, clear broths. Signature dishes: Sweet and sour carp, braised sea cucumber, dezhou braised chicken. Best in: Jinan, Qingdao.

4. Jiangsu (苏菜) -- Jiangsu

Known for: Delicate presentation, slightly sweet flavors. Signature dishes:

Squirrel-shaped mandarin fish, lion's head meatballs, Nanjing salted duck. Best in: Nanjing, Suzhou.

5. Zhejiang (浙菜) -- Zhejiang

Known for: Fresh, mellow flavors, seafood. Signature dishes: Dongpo pork, West Lake vinegar fish, Longjing shrimp. Best in: Hangzhou.

6. Fujian (闽菜) -- Fujian



Known for: Umami-rich broths, seafood soups. Signature dishes: Buddha jumps over the wall, oyster omelette, lychee pork. Best in: Fuzhou, Xiamen.

7. Hunan (湘菜) -- Hunan

Known for: Pure hot spiciness (without numbing), smoked meats. Signature dishes: Chairman Mao's red-braised pork, steamed fish head with chili, stir-fried smoked pork.

Best in: Changsha.

8. Anhui (徽菜) -- Anhui

Known for: Wild herbs, braised dishes, mountain ingredients. Signature dishes: Li Hongzhang hodgepodge, hairy tofu, bamboo shoots with cured meat. Best in: Huangshan.

Sources: Sources: [Ministry of Commerce](http://www.mofcom.gov.cn) • [China Daily Food & Culture](http://www.chinadaily.com.cn)

Article 2

Beijing Traditional Breakfast: 10 Must-Visit Spots Near the Forbidden City & Wangfujing

Beijing's traditional breakfast culture (老北京早点 lǎo Běijīng zǎodiǎn) is one of the city's most authentic culinary experiences. While tourists flock to the Forbidden City and Wangfujing, the real magic happens at dawn in the surrounding hutongs, where locals queue up for steaming bowls of douzhī, crispy jiaoquan, and golden youbings. Here are 10 legendary breakfast spots within walking distance of Beijing's top tourist landmarks.

What to Expect: A Beijing Breakfast Primer

A traditional Beijing breakfast is hearty, savory, and unlike anything you'll find in southern China. The "holy trinity" of Beijing breakfast is:

* Douzhī (豆汁)

* -- Fermented mung bean drink. Sour, slightly funky, and absolutely polarizing. Locals

love it; most foreigners need 2-3 tries. It's Beijing's ultimate litmus test.

* Jiaoquan (焦圈)

* -- Deep-fried dough rings, crispy like a savory donut. Always paired with douzhī.

* Yóutiáo (油条)

* -- Fried dough sticks. Dip in soy milk or wrap in a jianbing (煎饼). Universal

crowd-pleaser.

Other essentials: miàn chá (面茶, millet paste with sesame), zhū gāo (猪糕, steamed pork

cake), luóbo sī bǐng (萝卜丝饼, radish cake), and mén dīng ròu bǐng (门钉肉饼,

door-knocker meat pies).

1. Húguósi Xiǎochī (护国寺小吃) -- Huguo Temple Snacks

The undisputed king of Beijing traditional snacks. Founded in 1956, this state-owned



chain preserves recipes that date back centuries. The Huguo Si main branch is the most atmospheric, but the Dianmen branch near the Drum Tower is more convenient for tourists. Order the dòuzhī + jiāoquān combo, àndào cháng (鞍道肠, donkey intestine sausage -- better than it sounds), and the táng huǒshāo (糖火烧, sweet sesame flatbread).

06:00-21:00 | ¥15-30/person | Must-try: 豆汁+焦圈, 糖火烧, 驴打滚

2. Zēng Shèng Kuí (增盛魁)

A tiny, no-frills family-run stall near the Drum Tower that's been serving the same menu for 40+ years. No sign, no menu board -- just regulars who know exactly what to order.

The mén dīng ròu bǐng (门钉肉饼) here are the best in Beijing: thin, crispy shell bursting with juicy beef and scallion. The táng huǒshāo (糖火烧) is also exceptional. Cash only, no seats -- you eat standing on the sidewalk like a true Beijinger.

06:00-10:00 (早餐时段) | ¥10-20/person | Must-try: 门钉肉饼, 糖火烧

3. Bái Kuí Lǎo Hào (白魁老号饭庄)

Established in 1780 during the Qing Dynasty, Bai Kui is one of Beijing's oldest restaurants. Famous for its shāo yáng ròu (烧羊肉, roasted lamb) and miàn chá (面茶, millet paste topped with sesame sauce). The Jiadaokou branch is the most convenient for tourists. The lamb here is slow-roasted for hours until the exterior is caramelized and the interior melts. Their miàn chá is the gold standard -- creamy, fragrant, with perfect sesame-to-millet ratio.

06:00-21:00 | ¥25-50/person | Must-try: 烧羊肉, 面茶, 羊杂汤

4. Nán Lái Shùn (南来顺)

Nan Laishun is Beijing's Hui Muslim breakfast institution. Located near Niujie (Ox Street)

Mosque, it specializes in halal Beijing snacks. The zhà sāng dài (炸桑袋) and dòu miàn



huáng (豆面黄) are unique to this shop. Their yáng zá tāng (羊杂汤, lamb offal soup) is the best hangover cure in Beijing -- rich, peppery, loaded with tender lamb bits. The atmosphere is authentically old Beijing: communal tables, loud conversations, and zero English.

06:00-14:00 | ¥20-40/person | Must-try: 羊杂汤, 豆面黄, 炸桑袋

5. Dōnghuāmén Yè Shì (东华门美食坊) -- Donghuamen Breakfast Street

Right outside the Forbidden City's east gate (Donghuamen), this cluster of food stalls is the most tourist-friendly traditional breakfast spot. While it's more commercialized than hutong shops, the convenience is unbeatable -- grab breakfast before entering the Palace Museum at 8:30 AM. Look for the jiānbīng guǒzi (煎饼果子) stalls, shuǐjiǎo (水饺) vendors, and fresh dòujiāng (豆浆, soy milk) stands. Prices are slightly higher (¥15-25/person) but the location is prime.

06:00-10:00 (早餐) | ¥15-25/person | Must-try: 煎饼果子, 豆浆, 水饺

6. Tiānxīngjū (天兴居) -- Tianxing Ju

Tianxing Ju is famous for one thing: chǎo gān (炒肝, stir-fried liver) -- a thick, garlicky stew of pork liver and intestines in starch-thickened broth. It's the most iconic Beijing breakfast dish that tourists rarely try. Founded in 1862, this Qianmen institution serves chǎo gān the traditional way: in a small bowl, eaten by "drinking" it from the edge (never with a spoon -- that's the rule). Pair it with bāo zi (包子, steamed buns) for the full experience.

06:30-14:00 | ¥15-25/person | Must-try: 炒肝, 包子, 卤煮火烧

7. Lóngfǔ Sì Xiǎochī (隆福寺小吃店)

Once the heart of old Beijing's snack culture, Longfu Si was devastated by fire in 1993 and never fully recovered its former glory. But the surviving breakfast stalls still serve



excellent traditional fare. The dòuzhī (豆汁) here is particularly well-fermented, and the jiāo quān (焦圈) are always fresh. The area around Longfu Si is being redeveloped, so go soon -- this piece of old Beijing may not last forever.

06:00-10:00 | ¥10-20/person | Must-try: 豆汁, 焦圈, 艾窝窝

8. Dūyī Chù (都一处) -- Du Yi Chu

Du Yi Chu holds a special place in Beijing history: Emperor Qianlong reportedly visited in 1752 and bestowed the restaurant's name, meaning "The Only One." Famous for its shāomài (烧麦, open-top dumplings), the Qianmen flagship is a must-visit. While known for dinner, their breakfast service offers excellent jiaozi (饺子) and porridge. The building itself is a beautifully restored Qing Dynasty structure -- eating here feels like stepping into a period drama.

06:30-21:00 | ¥30-60/person | Must-try: 烧麦, 饺子, 小米粥

9. Jǐnfāng Yuánxiāo (锦芳元宵) -- Jinfang Tangyuan

Jinfang is the undisputed champion of yuánxiāo (元宵, sweet glutinous rice balls) --

especially during Lantern Festival when the queue stretches for blocks. But their

year-round breakfast menu is equally impressive. The lú dǎ gǔn (驴打滚, donkey rolling

in the mud -- actually a sweet bean-powder-coated rice cake) and ài wō wō (艾窝窝,

steamed rice balls with sweet filling) are handmade daily. Their jiāngmí pái (江米排,

sticky rice strips) are addictive.

06:00-20:00 | ¥15-30/person | Must-try: 驴打滚, 艾窝窝, 元宵(季节性)

10. Xīsì Bāozi Pù (西四包子铺)

Don't let the humble name fool you -- Xisi Baozi Pu is a Beijing institution. Their zhūròu

dà cōng bāozi (猪肉大葱包子, pork and scallion buns) are legendary: fluffy, juicy, and

perfectly seasoned. A plate of 10 buns + a bowl of zhōu (粥, congee) is the quintessential



Beijing working-class breakfast, and it'll cost you under ¥15. The Xisi location is a short walk from the Forbidden City's northwest corner. Go before 8 AM or face a 30-minute queue.

06:00-13:00 | ¥10-18/person | Must-try: 猪肉大葱包子, 小米粥, 炒肝

Pro Tips for Breakfast Explorers

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* Go early:

* Most traditional spots are best before 8:30 AM. Many items sell out by 9 AM. The real regulars eat at 6:30.

* Cash helps:

* While most places accept WeChat Pay and Alipay, some older stalls (like Zeng Shengkui) are cash-only. Bring small bills.

* Point and smile:

* English menus are rare outside Donghuamen. Learn these phrases: "这个" (zhège -- "this one"), "多少钱" (duōshǎo qián -- "how much"), "好吃" (hǎo chī -- "delicious").

* Skip the Starbucks:

* Seriously. You're in Beijing. Drink dòujiāng (豆浆, soy milk) or miàn chá (面茶) like the locals.

* Use Dianping:

* Download 大众点评 (Dianping) -- it's China's Yelp. Search "早点" (zǎodiǎn) or "早餐" (zǎocān) near your hotel for hidden gems.

Walking Routes from Tourist Landmarks

* From the Forbidden City (故宫):

* Exit via Donghuamen → walk to Donghuamen breakfast stalls (5 min) or continue to Longfu Si (15 min walk east).

* From Wangfujing (王府井):



* Walk north to Jiaodaokou for Bai Kui (20 min) or take Line 5 one stop to Dongsì for

Longfú Sì.

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* From Qianmen (前门):

* Walk into Xianyukou hutong for Tianxing Ju (5 min) or stay on Qianmen Dajie for Du Yi

Chu (3 min).

* From the Drum Tower (鼓楼):

* Walk west for Zeng Shengkui (3 min) or south for Huguo Sì Dianmen branch (10 min).

Sources: Sources: 大众点评 Dianping • The Beijinger • <a href="https://www.timeoutbeijing.com"

target="_blank">Time Out Beijing • 马蜂窝 Mafengwo

The background of the cover is a close-up, slightly blurred photograph of several dumplings in a bamboo steamer basket. The lighting is warm and focused on the dumplings. Overlaid on this background are several geometric shapes: a large red circle in the center, a smaller dark grey circle in the top left, a red rectangle in the top right, a red rectangle in the bottom left, and a dark grey circle in the bottom right.

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